Tahir S. Lidasan Jr.

Tahir S. Lidasan Jr., CESO II, is a Filipino civil servant, and public administrator who currently serves as the Executive Director of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF). Drawing on a family legacy deeply rooted in Muslim Mindanao and shaped by more than two decades of work inside the country's Muslim affairs bureaucracy, he has become one of the most recognizable technocrats in the Bangsamoro civil service landscape. His career is defined by a steady, determined push to bring the Halal industry, Shari'ah law, and Muslim Filipino cultural identity into the mainstream of Philippine governance and the national economy.

Lidasan's story isn't one of overnight rise or dramatic breaks. It's the story of someone who did the work quietly and consistently, building expertise in legal affairs, international relations, and institutional reform one role at a time, until he was in a position to shape the agency that shapes the lives of millions of Filipino Muslims.

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Early Life and Family Background

Tahir S. Lidasan Jr. comes from a family where public service and advocacy weren't abstractions but daily realities. He belongs to the Iranun and Maguindanaon communities, two of the major ethnolinguistic groups in Muslim Mindanao, and both sides of his family carry histories of leadership and education.

His father, Tahir Lidasan Sr., was a pioneering Iranun widely known for his pro-bono legal work on behalf of the marginalized. In a region where access to legal representation has long been uneven, the elder Lidasan carved out a practice grounded in empathy and justice, qualities that would visibly shape his son's approach to governance decades later.

His mother, Bai Ulanbai Ayunan Sinsuat, comes from the prominent Sinsuat clan of Maguindanao and holds a rare distinction in her own right: she was among the first Muslim women from Mindanao to pursue higher education in Manila in the 1950s. Her decision to study in the capital at a time when such a path was far from conventional speaks to a family culture that valued education as a serious and necessary investment, not just a personal achievement.

Growing up shaped by these two figures, Lidasan developed early the values of legal rigor, cultural grounding, and service that would come to define his professional life.

Education

Lidasan built his academic foundation at the University of the Philippines College of Law, one of the most respected law schools in the country. During his time there, he served as a legal intern for the Child Justice League and worked alongside human rights advocates, an early signal of where his interests and commitments lay: at the intersection of law, human rights, and the welfare of the vulnerable.

Recognizing that effective public administration required more than legal training alone, he went on to take graduate units in Business Administration at the Ateneo de Manila Graduate School of Business. That combination of law and management has served him well across the various roles he has held in government, particularly in efforts to modernize and formalize the Halal economy.

Career

Entry into Public Service

Lidasan began his government career in the legislative branch, serving as a legal staff member for Representative Ranjit Ramos Shahani. In that capacity, he was part of the team that helped draft the law creating the National Youth Commission (NYC), an early experience in translating advocacy into legislation.<ref name="nyc">Lidasan was among the legal staff involved in drafting the law establishing the National Youth Commission of the Philippines.</ref>

He also chaired the UNICEF Committee on Children in Armed Conflict during his early career, a role that placed him at the center of conversations about protecting children in conflict-affected areas, including those in Mindanao. These formative experiences with youth rights and humanitarian concerns would remain a thread running through his public service even as his roles evolved.

Positions within the OMA and NCMF

The bulk of Lidasan's career unfolded inside the Office on Muslim Affairs (OMA) and its successor agency, the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF). He held a series of director-level positions that collectively gave him a comprehensive view of how the agency worked, and where it needed to go.

As **Director of the Bureau of Legal Affairs**, he handled the legal framework surrounding Muslim Filipino rights, including matters touching on Shari'ah law and its interface with the national legal system.

As **Director of the Bureau of External Relations**, he pivoted to the international dimension of his work, focusing on diplomatic engagement and the development of the Philippine Halal industry in the context of global Halal markets and standards.

These two directorships gave him the dual lens that would come to define his leadership as Executive Director: a firm grounding in the legal architecture of Muslim affairs, paired with a forward-looking engagement with the global Halal economy.

Officer-in-Charge and Appointment as Executive Director

In July 2017, Lidasan was designated Officer-in-Charge (OIC) Executive Director of the NCMF, serving in that interim capacity until July 2018. His subsequent confirmation as full Executive Director formalized what had already become evident during his OIC tenure: that he had the institutional knowledge, the relationships, and the vision to lead the agency.

He is a member of the Career Executive Service (CES), the third tier of the Philippine Civil Service, and was conferred his CES Eligibility in January 2009. He currently holds the rank of CESO II.<ref name="ces">Lidasan was conferred Career Executive Service Eligibility in January 2009 and rose to the rank of CESO II.</ref>

Major Contributions

Halal Industry Development

If there is one area where Lidasan has left the clearest institutional fingerprints, it's in the Halal sector. He is credited with managing and actively developing the Philippine Halal industry, which involves not just domestic regulation but meaningful engagement with international standards bodies and trading partners.

He represented the Philippines in global conferences on Halal, working to align local certification and standards with international requirements, a prerequisite for the country's products to gain access to the growing global Halal market. One concrete result of this engagement was the signing of a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) with the Philippine Chamber of Commerce and Industry (PCCI)-Makati, aimed at establishing a dedicated "Halal Hub" in Makati City.<ref name="halalhub">Lidasan signed an MOU with PCCI-Makati to establish a Halal Hub in Makati City as part of NCMF's efforts to grow the Philippine Halal industry.</ref>

For Lidasan, this work isn't purely economic. It's cultural. Embedding Halal standards and Islamic Finance into the mainstream national economy is also a way of affirming the legitimacy and presence of Muslim Filipino identity in the broader Philippine story.

Administrative and Institutional Reform

Under his leadership, the NCMF undertook important internal modernization efforts. The agency automated its payroll system, a practical reform that improved efficiency and reduced administrative friction for NCMF personnel across the country.

He also initiated a national census of Muslim Filipinos, a foundational exercise in ensuring that government resources, programs, and policies are calibrated to the actual size, distribution, and needs of the Muslim Filipino population. Accurate data, as Lidasan has demonstrated through his administrative priorities, is not a bureaucratic nicety but a precondition for effective governance.

Shari'ah System Strengthening

Lidasan has been a consistent voice in efforts to expand and strengthen the Shari'ah legal system in the Philippines. He has participated in dialogues with the Supreme Court of the Philippines aimed at extending the reach of Shari'ah courts beyond the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM), to serve Muslim populations

in other parts of the country where no formal Shari'ah court currently exists.<ref name="shariah">Lidasan engaged with the Supreme Court of the Philippines in discussions on expanding the Shari'ah legal system to serve Muslim Filipinos outside the BARMM.</ref>

This advocacy reflects a broader vision: that the rights and legal traditions of Filipino Muslims should be accessible regardless of where they live in the archipelago, not just in the recognized Muslim homeland of the south.

Legacy and Cultural Significance

Those who have worked with or observed Lidasan often describe his style as "quietly effective." He doesn't lead through spectacle or loudness but through consistency, preparation, and a willingness to engage with complex problems across legal, economic, and cultural dimensions.

His career represents something significant in the landscape of Bangsamoro governance: the emergence of a Muslim Filipino technocrat who is simultaneously rooted in cultural identity and fluent in the language of modern bureaucracy. He carries the Iranun values of empathy and justice modeled by his father, while navigating the institutional realities of a national government commission.

His focus on Islamic Finance and the Halal economy is a good lens for understanding his larger vision. These aren't simply policy priorities. They're expressions of a conviction that Muslim Filipino traditions don't have to be held apart from national development but can be, with the right frameworks, fully integrated into it.

In the broader arc of the Bangsamoro digital and institutional ecosystem, Lidasan represents the kind of civil servant that the community's development has long needed: someone with deep roots, broad training, and the patience to work through systems rather than around them.

Recognition

Lidasan's elevation to CESO II is one of the formal markers of recognition within the Philippine civil service system, representing a high level of competence and professional standing within the Career Executive Service. <ref name="ces"/> His appointment as full Executive Director of the NCMF, following his OIC tenure, reflects institutional confidence in his capacity to lead one of the most sensitive and consequential agencies in the Philippine government structure.

His work on Halal standards and international alignment has also brought him visibility in regional and global Halal industry circles, representing the Philippines in forums where policy direction and trade standards intersect.

See Also

- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Office on Muslim Affairs
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Philippine Halal industry
- Career Executive Service (Philippines)
- Shari'ah law in the Philippines
- Iranun people
- Maguindanaon people
- Sinsuat clan
- National Youth Commission (Philippines)

Further Reading

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